Clarifying responsibilities and referral arrangements

Practical guide for institutions | I07

Make clear who acts when language-related barriers affect EMI learning, who provides specialist support and who resolves gaps in provision. Students should have a clear next step, while educators and services retain their respective responsibilities.

Using this guide: Use existing academic advising, student support and escalation procedures. I03 and I04 describe support pathways for students and educators; this guide clarifies ownership and coordination across those pathways.

1. Agree responsibilities across the institution

Discuss responsibilities with students, subject educators, language specialists, support services and program leaders. Confirm them through the institution's normal governance and operational arrangements.

Students engage with tasks, communicate difficulties where possible and participate in agreed support. Subject educators provide clear teaching and assessment guidance, review avoidable barriers and identify when specialist help may be needed.

Language specialists assess and support language needs within their remit. Relevant services address accessibility, wellbeing and resource access. Program and institutional leaders ensure provision is resourced and recurring gaps are addressed. Do not assign specialist functions to staff without the preparation and capacity to perform them.

2. Publish a clear starting point and route

Provide a simple explanation of where students and educators can start, what each service offers and how to contact it. Include booking steps, eligibility and likely next actions using the service's confirmed information.

Offer help for people who are unsure which route applies. Make explanations accessible, considering relevant ethnic-minority languages where feasible. Do not assume Vietnamese is everyone's strongest language or that peers can interpret sensitive information.

3. Refer using evidence and the person's involvement

Establish a referral process that asks staff to describe the task, observed difficulty, support already tried and question for the receiving service. Provide guidance and examples. Require the person's involvement and apply institutional requirements for consent and information sharing.

Referral guidance might use: "The student can identify the cause in a diagram but has difficulty explaining the causal relationship in English; could you advise on language support?" Make clear that educators contribute observations; appropriately qualified specialists conduct language assessment. Avoid unsupported diagnoses or assumptions based on ethnicity or accent.

4. Confirm the handover and continuing responsibilities

Agree which role confirms that the receiving service can respond, explains the next step and checks whether contact occurred. Set realistic follow-up arrangements with services and provide staff time for coordination.

A referral does not remove the subject educator's responsibility for inclusive teaching or the student's opportunity to seek clarification. Specialist support should connect with course demands where appropriate, without sharing unnecessary personal information.

5. Escalate unavailable or unsuitable provision

Agree a route to the responsible program or service lead when a referral is declined, support is inaccessible or the available provision does not meet the need. Identify what interim help is possible and who will communicate it.

Record the service gap through existing processes. Avoid repeated redirection between teams without an owner. Formal complaints, urgent concerns and assessment adjustments should use the relevant institutional procedures.

6. Review whether the arrangements work

Ask students and staff whether they knew where to start, reached the service and understood what would happen next. Check recurring unsuccessful referrals and unclear boundaries between services.

Update contacts, responsibilities and guidance when provision changes. Use patterns to improve the system rather than treating every unsuccessful referral as an individual failure.

7. Example establishing ownership across services

Program review identifies repeated cases of students being redirected between subject teaching and a general study-skills service. The institution finds no agreed responsibility for clarifying needs or checking that referrals reach a suitable service.

The program and service leads agree a coordination role, referral information and a follow-up process. Subject educators retain responsibility for teaching and disciplinary clarification; language specialists assess and support language needs within their remit. The leads check whether the arrangements reduce unsuccessful referrals and address gaps in capacity.

8. Review checklist

☐ Students, educators, specialists and leaders understand their responsibilities.

☐ A clear starting point and current contacts are available.

☐ Referrals describe tasks and evidence without unsupported diagnoses.

☐ Information sharing follows institutional requirements.

☐ A named person checks the handover and next step.

☐ Unmet needs have an escalation route and institutional owner.

9. When further institutional action is needed

Seek specialist provision when language barriers persist despite appropriate teaching support. Escalate service capacity, accessibility and coordination gaps to the responsible lead. Do not rely on students, classmates or individual educators to substitute indefinitely for unavailable institutional provision.

10.Related toolkit guidance

I02: identifying student needs. I03: student pathways. I04: educator pathways. I06: resources. I08: monitoring. D16–D17: sharing preferences and seeking support.

11.Supporting sources

Galloway, N., & Sahan, K. (2021). An investigation into English Medium Instruction in higher education in Thailand and Vietnam. British Council. Open source

Section 9, “Teacher recruitment and training” (p. 42), calls for clearer staff roles and communication of those roles to students and staff. It also discusses collaboration and embedded support.

Galloway, N. (Ed.). (2020). English in higher education – English medium. Part 1: Literature review. British Council. Open source

Pages 44–50 discuss context-specific support, consultation and collaboration between subject and language specialists. These principles inform coordination; they do not prescribe the referral process set out here.

The steps, example and checklist are toolkit adaptations for Vietnamese higher education. Sources support particular principles rather than the complete guide. The focus on ethnic-minority students and languages requires local consultation and evaluation. Developing draft for review; this is not a validated assessment or audit instrument.